



A 60-MINUTE CAREER EVIDENCE SYSTEM

Keep the Proof

How to Track Your Work Accomplishments
Before You Need a Resume

Build a private, usable record of your work before a review, promotion, job search, or unexpected change forces you to reconstruct it from memory.

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The record and the fine print

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What this guide is, and what it is not

This is an educational guide to keeping a private, permitted record of your own work. It is not legal advice. It cannot interpret your specific employment agreement, your non-disclosure obligations, your employer's policies, or the laws that apply where you work. Where a question of permission is genuinely unclear, treat that as a signal to leave the information out and to ask someone qualified, such as your manager, your human resources team, or an attorney.

A note on confidentiality before you begin

Everything in this system is built on one rule: you record only your own recollection of your work and information you are permitted to keep. You will be asked, repeatedly, not to copy, forward, photograph, download, screenshot, or reconstruct anything your employer owns. That rule holds on any device, at any hour, in any format. It is the first thing this guide teaches and the last thing it will let you forget.

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WELCOME

A short word before you start

Most people do excellent work and remember almost none of it clearly.

Not because the work was small. Because the work was constant. You solved the problem, absorbed the lesson, and moved to the next thing before the last one had a name. Months later a review, a promotion case, or a sudden change asks you to account for a year, and you find yourself reaching for details that have already gone soft.

I have spent eighteen years working close to where talent decisions get made: performance calibrations, promotion panels, restructurings, and the quiet conversations that precede all of them. The people who fared well in those rooms were rarely the ones who had done the most. They were the ones who could describe what they had done, accurately, without inflating it and without shrinking it. That skill is learnable. It is mostly a matter of keeping a record while the facts are still available to you.

Keep the Proof is that record and the discipline around it. It will not tell you what your career means or what move to make. It will help you hold on to the truth of your own work, in language a stranger can understand, kept in a way that respects the people you work for. That is a smaller promise than most career products make. It is also one you can actually keep.

Temidayo Afonja

Founder and Principal, The Density Group

ORIENTATION

What is inside, and how to use it

This guide has three jobs. It teaches you what career evidence is and what is not worth keeping. It gives you tools to capture and translate your work. And it builds those tools into short routines so the record maintains itself instead of becoming another thing you fall behind on.

The four things you will build

- A permitted private system. A place you own and control, holding only what you are allowed to keep.
- A capture habit. A two-minute method for catching work the moment it happens, and a fuller entry for the work that matters most.
- A translation skill. A repeatable way to turn internal labels and half-finished notes into accurate, portable language.
- Two light routines. A monthly sweep and a quarterly review that keep the record honest and current.

How to read it

You can read straight through in about an hour, or jump to the tool you need. If you want to start immediately, turn to the sixty-minute setup and follow it in order. Wherever a tool appears, a completed example appears with it, so you are never looking at an empty box wondering what belongs there.

The one rule that never bends

You record your own recollection and information you are permitted to retain. You never copy, forward, or reconstruct material your employer owns. If permission is unclear, you leave it out. Everything else in this guide sits underneath that rule.

PART One

Understand the record

What career evidence is, and why it goes missing

Before the tools, a clear idea of what you are keeping and what you are not. Most career records fail here, not in the formatting.

THE OPENING QUESTION

If your access disappeared this afternoon

If your work access disappeared this afternoon, how much of your career evidence would disappear with it?

Picture the ordinary version of a bad day. Not a scandal, just a change. A reorganization removes your login by five o'clock. A role is eliminated with two weeks' notice. A system migration wipes three years of your sent mail. You are fine, professionally and otherwise. But the record of what you did now lives in systems you can no longer open.

What would you still have? For most capable people the honest answer is: a current title, a rough sense of their projects, and a handful of numbers they are not quite sure of. The specific decisions, the problems they caught before anyone noticed, the exact shape of the thing they built, all of it sat inside the work, and the work is behind a door that just closed.

This guide is built for the stretch of time between two sentences. The first is I am doing the work. The second is I suddenly need to explain what the work amounted to. That gap is usually months or years long, and almost nobody uses it. Keep the Proof is how you use it.

THE PROBLEM

Why career evidence disappears

It is tempting to blame memory. Memory is part of it, but it is not the main cause. Career evidence disappears for reasons that are structural, and once you see them you can design around them.

It lives in systems you do not own

Your accomplishments are recorded, but not by you and not for you. They sit in a ticketing system, a shared drive, a customer platform, an email account, a chat history. Every one of those belongs to your employer. Access to them is a condition of your role, and it ends when the role does.

It is written in a private language

Inside a company, work is described in shorthand: project code names, internal acronyms, team rituals. That shorthand is efficient at work and meaningless everywhere else. A record written only in internal language is a record only your current employer can read.

The best parts are the least visible

The work that most deserves to be remembered often leaves the faintest trace. A judgment call that prevented a bad outcome produces no artifact, because the bad outcome never happened. Coordination across three teams shows up in no single person’s numbers. The quieter and more valuable the contribution, the more likely it is to vanish without a deliberate record.

It decays quietly

Details do not leave all at once. They fade. The figure you were sure of becomes approximate. The reason behind a decision blurs into the decision itself. Six months on, you can still tell the story, but you can no longer defend the specifics, and specifics are what a review or a resume runs on.

THE CATEGORY

What career evidence is, and is not

Career evidence is a truthful, private, retrievable record of what you contributed, what judgment you exercised, what changed because of your work, and what permitted information supports the account. That is the whole definition, and each word in it is doing work.

Career evidence is	Career evidence is not
A record of your contribution and judgment	A list of everything you were assigned
Written in language an outsider can follow	A wall of internal names and acronyms
Honest about your part in a shared result	A claim of sole credit for team work
Built only from what you may keep	A copy of files that belong to your employer
Useful before many career moments	A document you touch only when job hunting

It is disciplined recordkeeping, not self-promotion. The point is not to make your work sound impressive. The point is to make it accurate and findable, so that when a moment arrives that depends on the details, the details are there and you can trust them. Done well, an accurate record is more persuasive than an inflated one, because it holds up when someone asks a second question.

Some people call this a brag document. The name is understandable, and it is the last time this guide will use it. What you are building is evidence rather than bragging, and the difference is practical. Evidence holds up when it gives someone else something concrete to examine.

What is worth capturing

You cannot record everything, and you should not try. Activity is not contribution. Answering forty emails is activity. Deciding which of the forty actually needed a decision, and getting that one right, is contribution. The filter below keeps the record small and worth keeping.

Capture it if one of these is true

- You exercised judgment, made a decision, or chose between real options.
- Something changed, improved, or became possible because of what you did.
- You prevented a problem, a cost, a delay, or a risk that would otherwise have landed.
- You handled scope, scale, or complexity that a description of your title would not reveal.
- You coordinated, influenced, or unblocked work across people or functions.
- You received specific feedback, recognition, or a result you can honestly point to.

Let it go if it is only this

- Routine execution of your basic duties with nothing distinctive about how you did it.
- Attendance, hours, or effort with no observable change attached.
- A task you were assigned but did not meaningfully shape.

A simple test

Before you record something, ask: if I described this to a thoughtful stranger, would they understand what I actually contributed and why it mattered? If the honest answer is no, either find the contribution underneath the activity, or leave it out.

THE BOUNDARY

Evidence versus employer-owned artifacts

This is the distinction the whole system depends on, so it is worth stating plainly. Your career evidence is your own account of your work. An employer-owned artifact is the material itself: the deck, the model, the code, the client file, the report. The account is yours to keep. The artifact is not.

Yours to keep (your account)	Not yours (the artifact itself)
"I rebuilt the onboarding process and cut new-hire ramp time."	The onboarding deck, the HR system export, the employee list
"I found and closed a gap in how we granted system access."	The access logs, the security configuration, the audit tooling
"I led the vendor selection and negotiated better terms."	The signed contract, the pricing sheet, the internal cost model

Notice what the left column has in common. Each entry is a sentence you could say out loud in a hallway without exposing anything your employer owns. It describes your contribution and the change, at a level of detail that is yours to carry. The right column is the underlying material, and none of it belongs in a personal record, no matter how convenient it would be to keep.

The line you will learn to hear

If the thing you want to save is a file, a screenshot, an export, or a copy of anything produced at work, it is an artifact, and it stays behind. If it is your own sentence about what you did, it is evidence, and it comes with you.

THE METHOD

The Keep the Proof workflow

Every entry you make, from a two-minute note to a full record, moves through the same five steps. You will not think about them consciously for long. They become the shape of how you handle a piece of work worth keeping.

1 Capture Record it while the facts are fresh.	2 Clarify Separate the team result from your part.	3 Translate Put it in words an outsider understands.	4 Protect Keep only what you are permitted to hold.	5 Retrieve Tag it so you can find it when it matters.
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Read the five steps once, slowly

Capture is speed. The goal is to catch the work before the details soften, even if the note is rough. Clarify is honesty. You separate what the team achieved from what you actually did, and you name the judgment inside the task. Translate is reach. You convert internal shorthand into language someone outside your company could follow. Protect is permission. You confirm that everything you are keeping is yours to keep, and you leave out anything that is not. Retrieve is usefulness. You tag the entry so that when a review or a resume or a hard week arrives, you can find exactly what you need.

The order matters more than the names. Capture before you clarify, because a rough note beats a perfect memory you never wrote down. Protect before you retrieve, because a record you were not permitted to keep is worse than no record at all.

PART Two

Permission and protection

The standard that keeps this safe

The most valuable thing this guide does is tell you what not to keep. Permission comes before protection, and it comes before everything else.

Permission comes before protection

A secure personal device does not make information yours to retain.

This is the sentence to remember above all others. People reach for the wrong test constantly. They ask whether the information is stored safely, whether they used their own laptop, whether it happened after hours. None of those questions is the right one. The right question is whether you are permitted to keep the information at all. Security is what you do after you have established permission. It is never a substitute for it.

What does not create permission

- Using a personal device, a personal account, or your own phone. Ownership of the hardware does not transfer ownership of the information.
- Working outside office hours. Confidentiality obligations do not clock out at six.
- Generalizing, rounding, anonymizing, or otherwise “sanitizing” something. Softening the wording does not make restricted information yours.
- Believing the information is harmless, or that no one would mind. Permission is a fact about your agreements, not a guess about intentions.

The permission test

Before anything enters your record, ask one question: am I permitted to retain this outside my employer’s systems? If yes, keep your own high-level account of it. If no, or if you are not sure, leave it out and, where it matters, ask someone qualified. Uncertainty is not a yellow light. For this record, it is a red one.

INFORMATION RISK

The confidentiality and information-risk guide

This section is the one to read slowly, because it is the one most people get wrong in ways that are hard to undo. The guiding idea is simple. Your record is built from your own memory of your own work and from information you are clearly permitted to hold. It is never built by extracting, copying, or reconstructing what your employer owns.

Three tiers, one habit

Sort everything you might record into three tiers. With practice this becomes instant.

KEEP	Your own high-level recollection of what you did, decisions you made, problems you helped prevent, publicly disclosed outcomes, and anything your employer has expressly permitted you to retain.
CARE	Numbers, client or project detail, and internal context that may be sensitive. Seek permission, use only what is already public, or leave it out. When you are unsure, treat it as the next tier.
NEVER	Source code, credentials, security settings, customer or employee data, unreleased product detail, internal financials, privileged or legal material, trade secrets, and any document or file owned by your employer. Never copy, forward, screenshot, download, or reconstruct these anywhere.

Generalizing information does not create permission. Use generalized wording only after you have confirmed that you are permitted to retain the underlying information. Softening the words changes how something reads, not whether it is yours to keep.

The habit is to default downward. When something sits between Keep and Care, treat it as Care. When it sits between Care and Never, treat it as Never. You may lose some detail this way, but you will keep the record accurate and defensible.

INFORMATION RISK, CONTINUED

Lines that do not move

Some actions are outside the system entirely. They are not judgment calls and they are not softened by good intentions or careful storage.

- Do not forward, download, photograph, screenshot, print, upload, or copy employer-owned material into any personal system.
- Do not circumvent security controls, data-loss tools, access restrictions, monitoring, or retention rules to obtain something for your record.
- Do not retain source code, credentials, security configurations, customer or employee data, personal information, internal financials, privileged communications, unreleased product detail, trade secrets, confidential research, proprietary models, internal decks, or client materials.
- Do not paste confidential or employer-owned work information into an AI system of any kind.
- When permission is uncertain, omit the information and seek qualified advice. That is the whole procedure.

What the record actually runs on

Your own high-level recollection of what you did. Information that has been publicly disclosed. And anything your employer has expressly permitted you to retain. That is the entire supply. It is narrower than people expect, and it is enough.

This guide is educational and is not legal advice. It cannot read your employment agreement or your employer's policies. Where a question of permission genuinely matters, ask your manager, your human resources team, or an attorney before you keep anything.

SETUP

Choosing and securing a private system

Your record needs a home. The requirements are modest, and they come in a strict order: the content must be permitted first, and only then does the storage matter. Securing a record you were not allowed to keep does not fix the problem. It hides it.

Choose a home you actually control

- Use a private account that belongs to you, not an employer-owned account, drive, or device.
- A plain document, a personal notebook, or a simple notes app is enough. The tools in this guide work in any of them.
- Keep it in one place. A record scattered across four apps is a record you will not maintain.

Then secure it, in this order

- Protect it with a unique password and turn on multifactor authentication.
- Prefer storage that is encrypted and access-controlled.
- Keep a backup only where the underlying content is permitted to live.
- Never store the record on a device or in an account your employer owns or can reclaim.

Order of operations

Permission, then storage. Every time. A locked box is only as safe as your right to hold what is inside it. Establish that you may keep something before you decide where to keep it.

PART Three

The tools

Capture, translate, and build the record

Two levels of capture, a translation system, and the Proof Line. Every tool arrives with a finished example, not an empty box.

TOOL ONE

The Two-Minute Quick Capture

The quick capture exists for one reason: to catch the work before it fades, in the two minutes after it happens. It is deliberately small. Five short prompts, no perfect wording required. You are not writing the final version. You are making sure the final version is still possible later.

The five prompts

- What happened? The event or piece of work, in a line.
- What was my specific contribution or judgment? Your part, not the team's.
- What changed, improved, became possible, or was prevented? The consequence.
- Verifier role or permitted public reference. A role or a public source that could confirm it. Do not store a colleague's personal details.
- Confidential detail to keep out. Name it, so you remember to leave it out.

**Completed Quick Capture · Devin A.,
distribution center supervisor**

Operations · captured the same afternoon

WHAT HAPPENED

Recurring mispicks on the night shift were driving returns. I changed the pick-verification step and the error rate dropped.

MY SPECIFIC CONTRIBUTION

I noticed the errors clustered on one workflow, proposed a second scan at pack-out, and ran the two-week trial that proved it out.

WHAT CHANGED

Shipping errors on that line fell sharply and stayed down after the change was made permanent.

PERMITTED VERIFICATION

My operations manager, who approved the rollout. The improvement was later cited in a team update.

MUST STAY OUT

The internal error dashboards, customer order data, and the returns figures themselves. I keep my own account, not the reports.

Notice what the capture does and does not hold. It holds Devin's account and a person who could confirm it. It does not hold a single employer file. That is the pattern for every capture you make.

TOOL TWO

The Full Career Evidence Entry

When a piece of work matters enough to keep properly, you expand a quick capture into a full entry. The ledger below has room for everything that makes a contribution legible later. You will not fill every field every time, and you should not try. A strong entry with six good fields beats a padded one with sixteen.

The twenty fields, in order

Field	What it captures
Date or period	When the work happened, even approximately
Project or work event	The initiative, responsibility, or moment
Situation or need	The problem or condition you were responding to
Why it mattered	What was at stake if it went unaddressed
Formal responsibility	What you were assigned on paper
Actual ownership	What you truly drove, which is often different
Decision or judgment exercised	The call you made, and the options you weighed
Actions taken	What you actually did
People and functions involved	Who you worked with or influenced, by role
Scope and constraint	Scale, complexity, or the limits you worked within
Outcome or observable change	What was observably different afterward
Problem prevented	The cost, delay, or risk that did not land
Quantitative evidence, accurate and permitted	Numbers, only when accurate and permitted
Qualitative evidence or validation	Feedback, recognition, or credible validation
Team result vs. your honest part	The shared outcome, and your honest share of it
Internal wording, before translation	How it is said inside the company
Portable-language version	How you would say it to an outsider
Permitted evidence reference	Name the permitted source or location. Do not paste the artifact or confidential content here.
Confidentiality and permission check	Confirmed nothing restricted is being kept
Retrieval tags	Review, promotion, compensation, resume, interview, biography, transition

TOOL TWO, COMPLETED

A completed full entry

Here is the same tool, filled in. This is the first half of a full worked sequence that continues on the next pages: quick capture, to full entry, to a portable Proof Line, to a retrieval tag.

Full Career Evidence Entry · Maya O., onboarding program lead	People and HR · measurable and qualitative
PERIOD Second and third quarters of last year.	
PROJECT OR WORK EVENT Redesign of the new-hire onboarding program for a growing operations team.	
SITUATION OR NEED New hires were taking a long time to become productive, and early attrition was high. The existing program was a slide deck and a checklist.	
FORMAL RESPONSIBILITY VS. ACTUAL OWNERSHIP On paper I coordinated onboarding logistics. In practice I redesigned the program end to end: the sequence, the first-week plan, the manager's role, and the thirty-day check-in.	
DECISION OR JUDGMENT I chose to move the program from information delivery to a structured first month with clear milestones, over the easier option of simply updating the deck.	
OUTCOME OR CHANGE New hires reached full productivity noticeably sooner, and early departures dropped. Managers began asking to use the model for their own teams.	
QUANTITATIVE AND QUALITATIVE EVIDENCE Time to full productivity improved by a figure I recorded accurately at the time. Two department heads asked to adopt the approach, which I noted as it happened.	
CONFIDENTIALITY CHECK I keep my own account and the fact of the improvement. I do not keep the HR system data, the employee records, or the internal reports the numbers came from.	
RETRIEVAL TAGS Promotion, performance review, resume, biography.	

Responsibility, judgment, scope, and outcome

Four things separate a memorable entry from a forgettable one. Most records capture the first and skip the rest.

Assigned responsibility is where you start, not where you stop

Your job description tells a reader what you were supposed to do. It rarely tells them what you actually did. The gap between the two is where most of your real contribution lives. Record the assignment, then record what you drove beyond it.

Judgment is the part with no artifact

Anyone can list actions. Fewer people can name the decision underneath the actions: the option they chose and the ones they set aside. That choice is often the most valuable thing you did, and it leaves no trace unless you write it down. Capture the call, not only the task.

Scope makes size legible

A title hides scale. “Managed the rollout” could mean two people or two hundred, one region or twelve. Without inventing precision you do not have, note the scope you worked within: how many, how large, how complex, under what constraint. Scope is what lets an outsider size the work correctly.

Push past the action to the observable change

The weakest entries end with what you did. The strongest end with what became different because you did it. Push every entry one step past the action to the observable change, even when the change is modest. When recording the work, include the effort where it adds useful context and describe the outcome or observable change.

Capturing work with no clean metric

A great deal of valuable work produces no tidy number. Coordination, judgment, care, and prevention rarely come with a percentage attached. This does not make the work unrecordable. It means you describe the change in credible, concrete terms instead of forcing a figure that is not real.

Describe the before and the after

When there is no metric, there is almost always a contrast. What was true before your work, and what was true after? “The handoff between the two teams kept failing; after I redesigned it, work stopped falling through the gap” is credible evidence with no number in it, because a reader can picture both states.

Name the specific consequence

Vague improvement is not evidence. Specific improvement is. Not “made things better,” but “the weekly report that used to take two people a full day now takes one person an hour.” A concrete, honest particular is more persuasive than a round number you cannot defend.

Never invent the number

If you do not have an accurate figure, do not manufacture one. An invented metric is the fastest way to lose a reader’s trust, because the first careful question exposes it. A well-described qualitative result is stronger than a fabricated quantitative one. Accuracy is the entire value of this record.

Problems prevented and invisible contributions

The most undervalued work in any organization is the problem that never happened. Prevention leaves no artifact by definition. The outage you caught before it spread, the error you flagged before it reached a customer, the misunderstanding you resolved before it became a conflict: none of these produce a result you can point to, because the point is that there was no result.

Record the risk, the catch, and the likely path

To capture prevention honestly, name three things: the risk that was forming, what you noticed or did, and the outcome that was on its way if no one had acted. “A misconfiguration would have exposed internal access; I caught it in review and it was corrected before anything was affected” is complete evidence of judgment, with nothing invented and nothing exposed.

Stay honest about certainty

Prevention invites overstatement, so hold the line. You do not know for certain what would have happened. Say “would likely have” rather than “definitely would have.” The honest version is still strong, and it is the version that survives a follow-up question.

Prevention, captured honestly · Theo R., security analyst

Technology and cybersecurity · no clean metric, problem prevented

THE RISK FORMING

During a routine review I found that a group of accounts had been granted more access than their roles required.

WHAT I DID

I traced how the access had been assigned, flagged it, and worked with the owning team to correct it and to close the gap that had allowed it.

THE PATH AVOIDED

Left in place, the excess access would likely have become a real exposure. It was corrected before it was used.

KEPT VS. LEFT OUT

I keep my account of the judgment and the fix. I keep no logs, no account names, no security configuration, and no internal tooling detail.

Separating a team result from your part

Most meaningful work is shared, and shared work creates a recording problem. Claim the whole result and you are exaggerating. Claim nothing and you disappear from your own record. The skill is to state the team's outcome honestly and then name your specific part within it, without inflating and without vanishing.

Two sentences, always in this order

First, the shared result: what the group achieved. Second, your contribution: the particular thing you drove inside it. "The team delivered the platform migration on schedule. My part was owning the data-integrity plan and making the call to phase the cutover, which kept us from a rushed switch." Both sentences are true. Neither one steals from the other.

**A manager separating the two · Grace W.,
engineering manager**

Management · team outcome and honest
individual contribution

THE TEAM RESULT

My team of nine shipped a long-delayed platform migration, on time, with no major incidents.

MY ACTUAL CONTRIBUTION

I did not write the migration. My part was sequencing the work, protecting the team from mid-project scope changes, and deciding to run a phased cutover instead of a single switch.

THE JUDGMENT INSIDE IT

The phased approach was mine to argue for and mine to own. It is the reason a risky switch did not become a bad weekend.

PORTABLE VERSION

Led a nine-person team through a complex platform migration, delivered on schedule with no major incidents, and set the phased rollout approach that protected reliability during the transition.

TRANSLATE

From internal language to portable language

A record only your current employer can read is a record that expires when you leave. Translation is the skill of saying the same true thing in words an outsider can follow. It is not embellishment and it is not lying. It is the difference between a private shorthand and a description that travels.

Eight translation moves, plus one protection rule

Most entries need one of the eight translation moves below. The final line is different: it is a protection rule for sensitive information.

Move	Turn this	Into this
Name to function	"Ran Project Northwind"	"Led the customer-data migration"
Assignment to contribution	"Responsible for reporting"	"Rebuilt the reporting so leaders could act on it"
Activity to consequence	"Held weekly reviews"	"Caught risks early enough to prevent slippage"
Team to your part	"We launched it"	"I owned the rollout plan for the launch"
Acronym to meaning	"Cleared the KYC backlog"	"Cleared a backlog of customer identity checks"
"Helped with" to real role	"Helped with the audit"	"Prepared the evidence and answered the auditors directly"
No number to credible detail	"Improved the process"	"Cut a two-day task to a few hours"
Number to scale	"Handled 40 accounts"	"Managed 40 enterprise accounts across three regions"
Sensitive to permitted	"Fixed the breach in system X"	"Resolved a security issue and closed the gap behind it"

Why the last line is different

The first eight moves make your work clearer. The last one keeps you safe. Turning sensitive detail into a permitted, high-level description is never a way to smuggle restricted information out in disguise. If the only accurate version would expose something you may not keep, the correct move is to omit it, not to reword it.

BUILD

The Proof Line

A Proof Line is a single, plain-language sentence that carries the most useful parts of an entry in a form you can drop into a review, a resume, or a conversation. It is the portable end product of everything the record holds. You build it by combining, in whatever order reads well, up to five ingredients.

The five ingredients

- The condition. The problem or situation you were responding to.
- Your part. The contribution, decision, or judgment that was yours.
- The scope or constraint. The size or the limits you worked within.
- The outcome. What changed, or what was prevented.
- The support. The permitted evidence or validation, when you have it.

Built in front of you

Ingredient	Maya's onboarding work
Condition	New hires were slow to become productive and left early
Your part	Redesigned the onboarding program end to end
Scope	For a growing operations team, across the full first month
Outcome	Faster time to productivity and lower early attrition
Support	Adopted by two other department heads

Maya's Proof Line

"Redesigned new-hire onboarding for a growing operations team, cutting time to full productivity and reducing early attrition, with the model later adopted by two other departments."

A Proof Line does not need a number to be strong, and it must never contain an invented one. It also never claims sole credit for a shared result. If a line would only sound impressive by overstating your ownership, it is not finished. It is wrong.

SEE IT WORK

Before and after

Translation is easiest to learn by watching it happen. Each pair below keeps the same underlying truth. The weaker version is internal, vague, or overclaimed. The stronger version is portable, specific, and honest.

Weaker (internal, vague, or overclaimed)	Stronger (portable, specific, honest)
"Owned the Q3 OKR for the CS org"	"Set and delivered the quarter's top goal for the customer support team"
"Helped migrate to the new platform"	"Owned the data-integrity plan for a platform migration and phased the cutover to protect reliability"
"Improved team efficiency"	"Redesigned a weekly reporting task from two days to a few hours"
"Single-handedly saved the launch"	"Made the call to delay one day to fix a data issue, which kept the launch from shipping broken"
"Handled a security thing"	"Found and corrected an access gap in review before it could be exploited"
"Did a lot of cross-functional work"	"Coordinated three teams to resolve a recurring handoff failure between them"

Read the right-hand column again and notice what none of them do. None invents a number. None claims a whole team's work. None exposes a name, a system, or a file. They are simply the true thing, said well enough to travel.

PART Four

Worked examples

The record, filled in across real work

Different functions, different levels, one discipline. Two examples run the full sequence from capture to retrieval tag.

EXAMPLES

Two more completed examples

You have already seen four people's records take shape: Devin in operations, Maya in people and HR, Theo in security, and Grace in engineering management. Two more complete the set, chosen to show the hardest cases: work where the right choice is to leave detail out, and work whose whole value is judgment rather than output.

Priya N., senior internal auditor

Finance, audit, and risk · a sensitive context, handled by omission

THE WORK

I led an internal audit of a financial process and identified a control weakness that had gone unnoticed for some time.

THE JUDGMENT

I decided which findings were material enough to escalate and how to frame them so they would be acted on rather than argued with.

WHY THIS ONE IS DELICATE

The subject matter is sensitive and specific to my employer. The correct record is my own high-level account, not the findings, the figures, or the systems involved.

PORTABLE VERSION

Led an internal audit that surfaced a significant control weakness, and framed the findings so leadership acted on them. No confidential detail retained.

KEPT VS. LEFT OUT

Kept: my role, my judgment, the fact of the outcome. Left out: the specific process, the numbers, the named systems, and every working paper.

Sam B., clinical research coordinator

Healthcare and research · value from coordination and influence, not output

THE WORK

A study was stalling because three groups (clinical staff, data management, and an external partner) were working from different assumptions.

MY ACTUAL CONTRIBUTION

I had no formal authority over any of the three. My part was seeing why they were stuck, building a shared plan, and keeping it moving without a title that required them to listen.

THE OUTCOME

The study got back on schedule. My name appears on no deliverable, because the contribution was the coordination itself.

PORTABLE VERSION

Coordinated three functions with no formal authority to unblock a stalled research study and return it to schedule, working through influence rather than mandate.

FULL SEQUENCE, END TO END

One item, all the way through

Here is a single piece of work carried through the entire system: quick capture, to full entry, to Proof Line, to retrieval tag. This is the second full sequence, using Theo's prevention work from earlier.

1 · Quick Capture · Theo R., security analyst

Two minutes, the same day

WHAT HAPPENED

Found over-broad access on a set of accounts during a routine review.

MY CONTRIBUTION

Traced how it happened, flagged it, and drove the fix and the process gap behind it.

CHANGED / PREVENTED

A likely exposure was prevented before the excess access could be used.

VERIFICATION

The owning team's lead, who made the correction with me.

STAYS OUT

All logs, account names, tooling, and configuration.

2 · Full Entry · the fields that matter here

Expanded when the item proved worth keeping

FORMAL VS. ACTUAL

Assigned to routine access reviews; actually drove a correction and a process change.

JUDGMENT

Chose to treat a quiet finding as urgent and to fix the cause, not just the instance.

OUTCOME

The excess access was removed, and the process gap that allowed it was closed.

EVIDENCE

No clean metric. Credible qualitative outcome, confirmed by the owning team.

3 · Proof Line → 4 · Retrieval Tag

The portable end product, tagged for later

PROOF LINE

"During a routine access review, I found and corrected over-broad account access and closed the process gap behind it, preventing a likely exposure before the excess access could be used."

RETRIEVAL TAGS

Performance review, promotion, resume, interview (judgment and prevention).

PART Five

The routines and the use

Keep it current, and use it when it counts

An hour to set up, a few minutes a month, a review each quarter. Then the record earns its keep at the moments that decide careers.

START HERE

The complete 60-minute setup

This is the first hour. Follow it in order and you will finish with a working system and your first real entries. It is not a promise that you can reconstruct a whole career in sixty minutes. It is a promise that you can leave the hour with the system running and something true already in it.

Time	What you do
0–10 min	Read the permission rule and the three tiers again. Choose a private home you control and turn on a password and multifactor authentication. Storage comes after permission, not before.
10–20 min	Sweep your own memory and permitted sources for the last few months. No employer files. Just what you can recall and what is already public: projects, decisions, moments that mattered.
20–40 min	Write at least three Quick Captures from that sweep. Rough is fine. Speed beats polish.
40–50 min	Expand your strongest capture into a Full Entry. Fill only the fields that apply.
50–57 min	Translate that entry into one portable Proof Line.
57–60 min	Schedule the next Monthly Proof Sweep and the next Quarterly Proof Review. Put both on a calendar you control.

What you have at minute sixty

A private system you control, three or more captured items, one full entry, one portable Proof Line, and two recurring dates. That is a working record. Everything after this is maintenance.

The monthly and quarterly routines

A record is only useful if it stays current, and it only stays current if maintaining it is nearly effortless. Two routines do this. The monthly sweep is short and additive. The quarterly review is longer and corrective. Neither one asks you to diagnose your career. They only keep the evidence honest.

The Monthly Proof Sweep • about 10 to 15 minutes

- Look back over the month's projects, decisions, feedback, changes, and problems you helped prevent.
- Add Quick Captures for anything worth keeping. Rough notes, quickly.
- Expand the single most significant item into a Full Entry.
- Run the confidentiality check: is everything here permitted?
- Tag each item for how you might retrieve it later.

The Quarterly Proof Review • about 30 minutes

- Read the quarter's entries in one sitting.
- Remove duplicates and anything too vague to be useful.
- Correct overstatement and add missing context while you still remember it.
- Translate the strongest entries into portable Proof Lines.
- Note where evidence is thin, without drawing any conclusion about your career from the gap.
- Write a short quarterly index of your best entries, and set the date for the next review.

What this is not

The quarterly review is housekeeping, not a verdict. Noticing that you have little evidence of a certain kind of work is a prompt to capture more of it, nothing more. This record organizes and translates what happened. It does not tell you what your career means. That is a different tool, and a later page points to it quietly.

USE IT

Retrieving the right evidence

The whole point of tagging is this moment: something is about to happen, and you need the right entries fast. This section tells you which kinds of entries to pull for each occasion. It is a guide to retrieval, not a course in how to interview, negotiate, or write a resume. It gets you the raw material. What you do with it is yours.

When this arrives	Pull entries that show
Performance review	Outcomes and prevented problems from the review period, with honest scope
Promotion case	Judgment, ownership beyond your title, and work at the next level
Compensation discussion	Scope, results, and contributions others have recognized
Internal application	Work relevant to the new team, translated out of your current group's language
Resume preparation	Your strongest Proof Lines across roles, each one honest and portable
Interview preparation	Entries with a clear situation, your decision, and the result, ready to tell aloud
Biography or introduction	A few durable, senior-sounding contributions stated plainly
Proposal or portfolio	Permitted outcomes that show the kind of work you deliver
Unexpected transition	Everything, quickly, because the record is now the only copy you have

STARTING LATE

If your access has already disappeared

Perhaps you are reading this after a change, not before one. The record you wish you had does not exist, and the systems that held the details are closed. This is recoverable. It is not as complete as capturing in real time, but a great deal can be reconstructed honestly from what is still yours.

Work only from what you are permitted to use

Your own memory is yours. Publicly disclosed outcomes are usable. Anything a former employer expressly permitted you to keep is usable. What is not usable is a copy of anything you took, or access you were not meant to retain. The rule does not relax because the timing is inconvenient.

- Reconstruct by period. Take each role or year in turn and recall its major projects and decisions.
- Anchor to moments you remember clearly: a hard call, a launch, a problem you caught, a piece of feedback.
- Write Quick Captures from memory, then expand the strongest into full entries.
- Mark anything uncertain as uncertain. An honest approximate record is worth far more than a confident wrong one.
- Then start capturing in real time, so you never have to reconstruct again.

Reconstruction has a ceiling, and it is worth naming: you will not recover everything, and you should not pretend to. Capture what you can defend, note what you cannot, and let the going-forward habit do the rest.

OPTIONAL

An optional, privacy-conscious AI prompt

Everything in this guide works without any AI. This tool is optional, and it is for one narrow job: helping you translate an entry you have already written into portable language. Before the prompt, the rule that governs it.

Before you use it

Never paste employer names, customer names, colleague names, proprietary detail, employee information, sensitive metrics, code, security information, or any confidential material into an AI system. Give it only your own non-confidential account, already stripped of anything you may not keep. The permission rules in this guide apply to AI tools exactly as they apply to everything else.

The prompt

“You are helping me describe my own work accurately for my private career record. I will give you only non-confidential information about what I did. Work only with what I provide. If context is missing, ask me for it rather than inventing anything. Never invent numbers, percentages, or results. Preserve my actual level of ownership, and keep any team result separate from my individual contribution. Translate internal language into plain, portable language an outsider could understand. Give me a few accurate versions for different uses: a short resume line, a spoken interview version, and a one-line summary. Flag anything that sounds inflated, vague, or unsupported so I can correct it.”

The AI does not decide what is true. You do. Treat every version it returns as a draft to check against your own memory and this guide’s rules, never as a finished record.

Reusable ledger pages

Use the fillable pages that follow to begin now. The standalone Career Evidence Ledger, included with your purchase, repeats these same forms so you can reuse them indefinitely without reprinting the handbook. Every response field is fillable on screen and prints cleanly if you would rather write by hand.

Two-Minute Quick Capture

One capture per page. Print or copy this page whenever you need another.

What happened?

The event or piece of work.

What was my specific contribution or judgment?

Your part, not the team's.

What changed, improved, became possible, or was prevented?

The consequence.

Verifier role or permitted public reference

Use a role or public source. Do not store a colleague's personal details.

Confidential detail to keep out

Name it, so you remember to leave it out.

FILL IT IN

Full Career Evidence Entry

Page one of three. Expand a Quick Capture into a complete entry, and fill only the fields that apply.

Date or period

Project or work event

Situation or need

Why it mattered

Formal responsibility

Actual ownership

Decision or judgment exercised

Actions taken

Full Career Evidence Entry

Page two of three.

People and functions involved

Scope and constraint

Outcome or observable change

Problem prevented

Quantitative evidence, accurate and permitted

Qualitative evidence or validation

Team result vs. your honest part

Full Career Evidence Entry

Page three of three.

Internal wording, before translation

Portable-language version

Permitted evidence reference

Name the permitted source or location. Do not paste the artifact or confidential content here.

Confidentiality and permission check

Retrieval tags

Review, promotion, compensation, resume, interview, biography, transition.

The Keep the Proof operating summary

Everything in this guide, on a single page you can return to.

The rule

Keep your own account and what you are permitted to retain. Never copy or reconstruct what your employer owns. When unsure, leave it out.

The workflow

Capture it fresh. Clarify your part from the team's. Translate it into portable words. Protect by keeping only what is permitted. Retrieve it by tagging for later.

The tools

A two-minute Quick Capture for speed. A Full Entry for what matters. A translation into portable language. A Proof Line as the portable end product.

The rhythm

An hour to set up. Ten to fifteen minutes each month to add. Thirty minutes each quarter to correct and index.

The use

Pull the right entries for reviews, promotions, compensation, internal moves, resumes, interviews, biographies, proposals, and sudden change.

If you remember only one line

A secure personal device does not make information yours to retain. Permission comes first. Everything else is craft.

Where Keep the Proof ends

This guide has a deliberate boundary, and naming it is part of using it well. Keep the Proof organizes and translates the record of your work. It does not interpret what that record means for your position, your direction, or your next move. Those are real and important questions. They are simply not this tool's questions.

What this guide answers

- What happened, and what was my contribution?
- What decision or judgment did I exercise?
- What changed, and what evidence supports it?
- How do I describe it truthfully in portable language?
- Where and how should I keep a permitted record of it?

What it deliberately does not answer

- Whether my career is stalled, or what state it is in.
- Whether this role is still building me, or whether I should stay or leave.
- What move I should make, or what my next strategy should be.

A quiet pointer, not a sales pitch

Keep the Proof organizes and translates the record. If you later want to interpret what your current work is actually building toward, a separate tool from The Density Group, the Capability Formation Field Kit, is designed for exactly that reading. It is a different job for a different day. This guide's work is done when your record is honest, portable, and safe to keep.

ABOUT THE AUTHOR

About Temidayo Afonja

Temidayo Afonja is the Founder and Principal of The Density Group. For eighteen years, Temidayo has worked across Big Four consulting, life sciences, and technology, close to where talent decisions get made, at the intersection of workforce strategy, organizational design, and how careers actually form.

That path into this work began in IT audit and federal governance, and moved through cybersecurity workforce strategy before that field had its current name. That background is the reason the confidentiality and information-risk standard in this guide is treated with the seriousness it deserves, and the reason it is careful never to overstate what any guide can settle for you. Keep the Proof is educational, not legal advice, and it cannot interpret your specific agreements or your employer's policies.

Keep the Proof grew out of a pattern that repeats in room after room: capable people who had done the work and could no longer prove it, reaching for details that had already gone. This guide is the discipline more of them needed.

Keep the record while the facts are still yours to keep.

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